

SUN WORSHIP AND sacrifice

INCAS AND AZTECS

Both Inca and Aztec societies were known for practicing human ritual sacrifice in the 15th and early 16th centuries. The Inca Empire ruled much of western South America, while the Aztec Empire was the most powerful force in present-day Mexico. Both worshiped sun gods, and women played significant roles as priestesses of their religions. Indeed, the Inca high priestess, the Coya Pasca, was believed to be Inti the sun god's earthly consort.

Aztec priestesses, *cihuatlamacazqui*, were celibate, and were responsible for decorating the temples and making preparations for rituals. In the Inca religion, *Aclla* ("chosen women") played a similar role. *Aclla* were selected aged 8–10 and sent to schools called *acclahuasi* to learn to make textiles and *chicha* (alcohol used in rituals). They took vows of chastity, tended sacred fires, and prepared food for ceremonies. After their service ended, a select few became *mamaconas*, known by the Spanish as "Virgins of the Sun." *Mamaconas* never married, but worked at temples and trained girls to be "chosen women." Former *aclla* were given as wives to nobles to cement alliances, or were ritually sacrificed. "The Maiden," a frozen mummy found in Argentina, was thought to have been an *aclla*. She had been left at the top of a volcano to die at the age of 13, and studies of her body suggest that she had been sedated over time with *chicha* and cocoa.

Entering womanhood

Women's roles in Inca households were not dissimilar to their roles in temples. They were in charge of preparing meals, cleaning, making clothing, collecting fuel, and



◀ *Accla* figurine

The "Chosen Women" were poor Inca girls who lived and served at the temples. They were chosen based on their talents and attractiveness, then spent about six or seven years unable to leave the temple.

childcare. Gender roles were also clearly defined in Aztec society; when a girl was born, a midwife placed a miniature distaff, spindle, staff, or broom in her hand. This was then buried with the umbilical cord under a metate (a stone for grinding corn) to symbolize a woman's household duties.

In Inca society, a girl became a woman at her first menstruation. She was house-bound for three days, then her relatives assembled and the girl was sent out to serve them food and drink. She got her first haircut, received gifts, and was given a permanent name by her most senior uncle. Inca women typically married between the ages of 16 and 20. The ceremony was simple: the groom and his family traveled to the bride's house and placed a sandal on her foot—made of wool if she was a virgin and grass if she was not.

While the Inca did not expect all women to stay chaste, the Aztecs believed that pre-marital sex was dangerous and led to diseases. Aztec girls married at around 15, and had an elaborate ceremony in which they were decorated with feathers and bright colors. A bride spent four days in a bedchamber with her husband, emerging to make offerings at the family altar, before they finally consummated the marriage.

The largest
acclahuasi
housed
1,500
chosen girls

◀ Brutal punishment

This Spanish colonial portrait of an Inca princess likens her to Mama Occollo, the first queen of the Inca dynasty, who allegedly beheaded all men who attempted to violate her sacred vow of chastity.